SPECULATIVE DESIGN · INTERACTION & SOUND · WORKING PROTOTYPE

The *Reader*

A phone-first field instrument for listening, from *The DACian Era*. Hear the place you stand in, find the sound traces others left nearby, and leave your own.

dacian-era-cglt.onrender.com → Best on a phone, with headphones



ROLE

Concept, world-building, research, UX/UI, sound & interaction design

BUILT WITH

HTML, CSS, JS, Web Audio, Canvas, a small Node server

CONTEXT

M.Des Human Centred Design, Srishti Manipal Institute

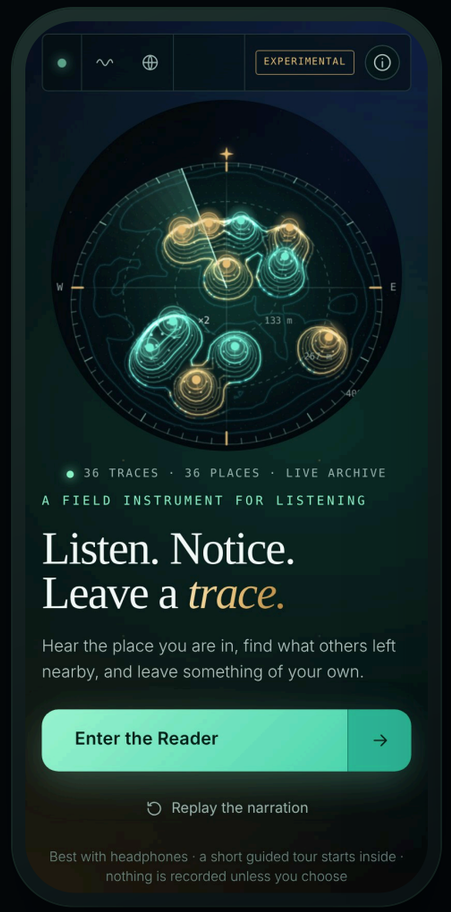
OVERVIEW

Three pages, one *instrument*

The Reader turns a speculative world into something you can hold in the street. It has no accounts and no feed, only places and what was left in them.

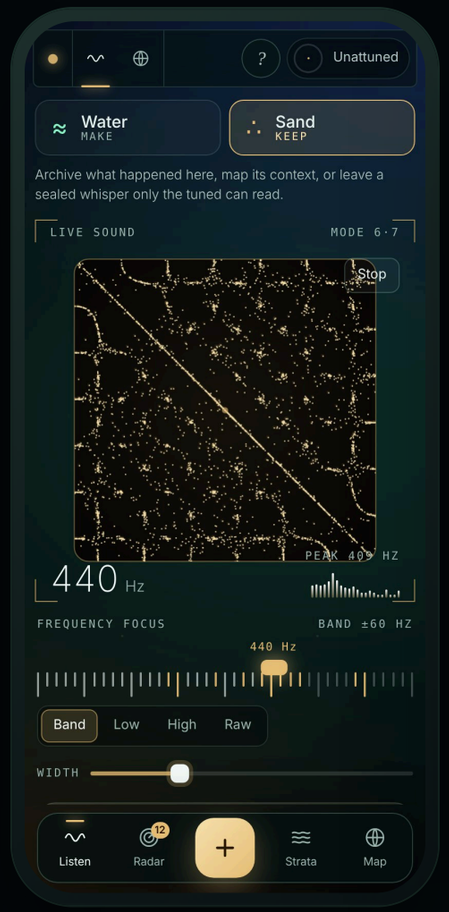
AN EARNED NAME

After a while of use, an anonymous name such as *Folded Backwater ·11* reveals itself. It reflects the element you lean toward, and you can rename it.



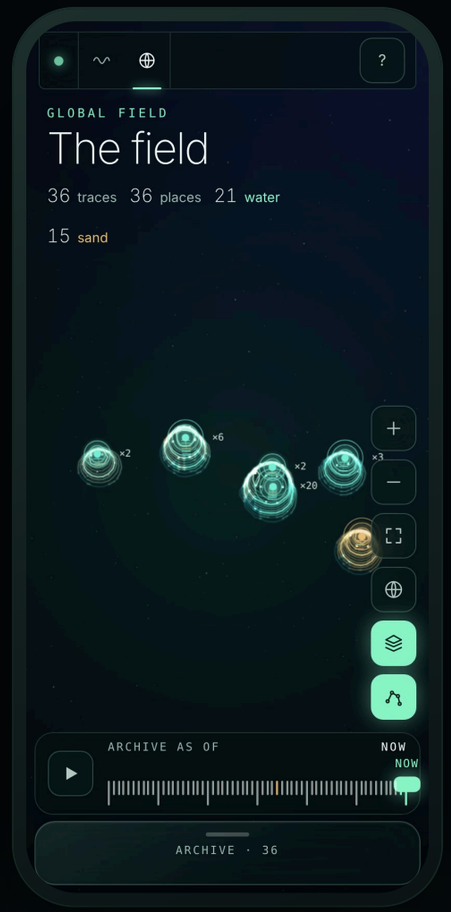
Entrance

A one-minute intro scored with ambience, then a live radar of the shared archive.



Reader

The instrument: listen, see sound as cymatics, find nearby traces, leave your own.



Global map

Every trace in the world as terrain, with constellations between related traces.

SCREENS FROM A LOCAL RUN WITH SAMPLE TRACES

THE WORLD

Memory, carried as *material*

In *The DACian Era*, places hold **filaments**: residues of sound, voice and event that settle into the ground. A **Reader** tunes into them, hears what a place remembers, and adds to it.

≈ WATER · MAKE

Carries and mixes. Flow, overlap, making new things from what is found.

∴ SAND · KEEP

Holds and orders. Sediment, record, and quiet messages.

“The world is not decoration on top of the app. It is the reason each feature behaves the way it does.”

THE QUESTION

How might a tool help people listen more closely to a place, and leave something there for others, without turning listening into content or the listener into a profile?

01 **Listening first.** Worth opening even if you never record.

02 **Bound to place.** What you hear depends on where you stand.

03 **Anonymous, not faceless.** No sign-up; identity grows from use.

04 **Choices with consequences.** Water and Sand open different work.

RESEARCH & REFERENCES

Four sources *shaped* the work

01

World documents

The world bible and Fillámend reference set the vocabulary, the two elements and the rules of memory in place.

02

Visual references

Holographic topography, contours, point clouds, constellations. The *Entry Page Redesign* set the entrance tone.

03

Cymatics

Bessel standing waves for water, Chladni figures for sand, and cymatics apps for how patterns follow pitch.

04

Listening practice

Soundwalking, field recording and locative audio: reward slow attention, not quick capture.

WHAT IT SETTLED

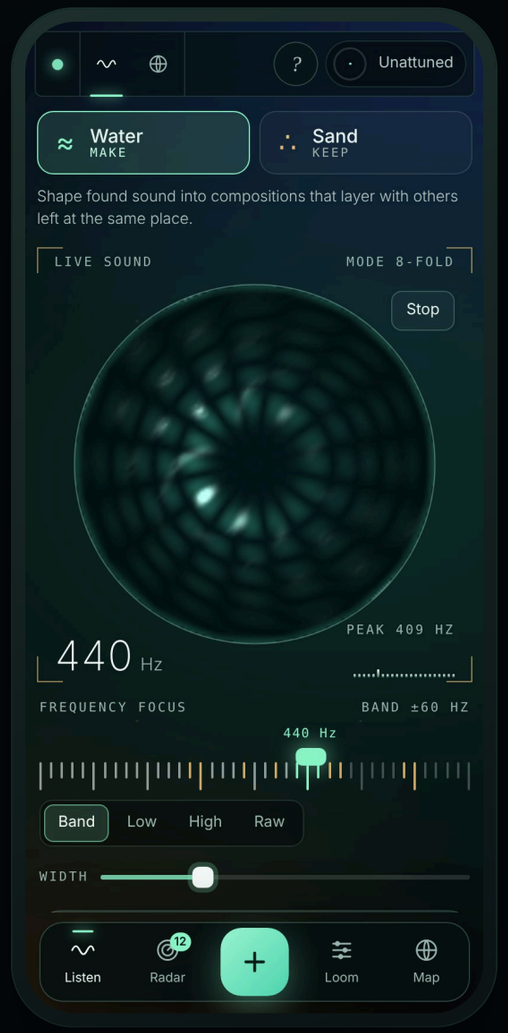
- ◇ **Sound drives the visuals.** Every visual listens to something.
- ◇ **On a phone, the map is the interface.** Controls sit around it, never over it.
- ◇ **Anonymity needs a replacement for the profile.** The earned name grew from this.

FROM CONTROLLED PROTOTYPE TO EXPERIMENTAL READER

A demo became a *working instrument*

The first version used fixed example traces in separate laptop and phone mock-ups. It showed the idea, but not what happens when real people leave real traces.

THE AUDIT FOUND		THE REDESIGN
Radar and map showed hard-coded examples	→	A live, shared archive that updates in seconds
Saved traces disappeared (missing endpoint)	→	A traces API with an offline queue on the phone
Water and Sand only changed the colour	→	Two real paths: compose together, or archive
A busy entrance, many competing messages	→	One message, one action, a calm live radar
No introduction to the world	→	A one-minute intro and guided coach-mark tours



WATER · BESSEL STANDING WAVES

THE KEY DECISION

Choose by *need*, not by colour

≈ WATER · MAKE

The Loom

Record found sound and place it on a 4×16 step grid. Each place has its own tempo on the shared clock, so everyone's compositions overlap as one song.

∴ SAND · KEEP

Strata

Leave records of events and link them into context maps, or seal a whisper that opens only within 25 m, tuned to the right pitch.

Both patterns are drawn live from the microphone: pitch picks the mode, loudness drives the energy.



SAND · CHLADNI FIGURES

KEY DECISIONS

What we chose, and *why*

No accounts
Name earned from element use, editable. Anonymous, with a sense of self.

Shared clock
Loom runs on the wall clock with a tempo per place. Collaboration needs no syncing.

Sealed whispers
Open within 25 m at the right pitch. Honest: a ritual lock, not a vault.

Holographic field
Contours, point cloud, constellations. The archive becomes terrain, not a list.

Vicinity sound
Traces play from their direction and fade with distance. A soft VR layer.

Ambience, not voice
The TTS voice broke the mood. Tide, Dune and Hum carry tone instead.

Visuals that listen
Ambience recolours and moves the intro. Cymatics follow the mic.

Tours in context
Coach marks on Reader and Map. Permissions asked when needed.

Phone first
From 320 px up, laptop kept. It is used outdoors, in place.

One navigation
Same nav on every page, labels on every icon. No guesswork.

One action
Each screen has a single primary action. Everything else steps back.

Authorship
A credit line and About panel, so the work reads as the creator's own.

THE EXPERIENCE

Eight *moments*

01 **Arrive.** One Start tap, six lines over a moving field.

02 **Enter.** One headline, one action, a live radar.

03 **Tour.** Nine coach marks; location asked at the radar.

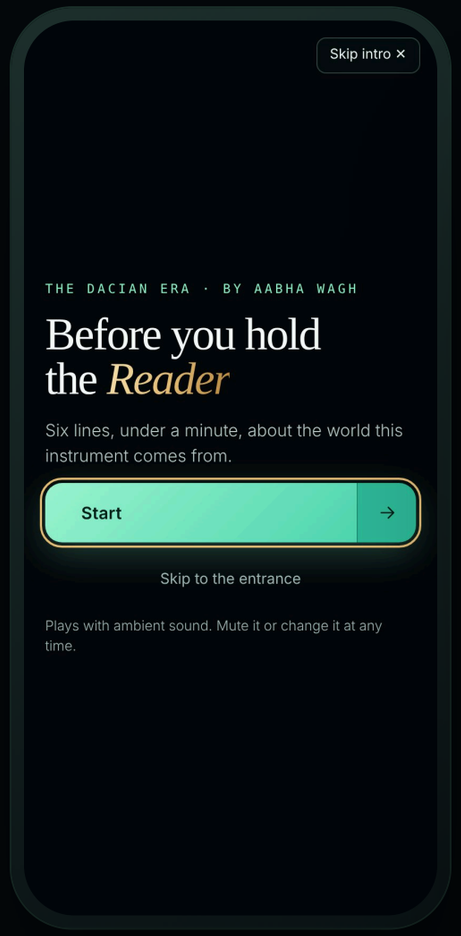
04 **Listen.** Cymatics, filters, delay, reverb, Freeze.

05 **Find.** Vicinity mode: traces sound from where they are.

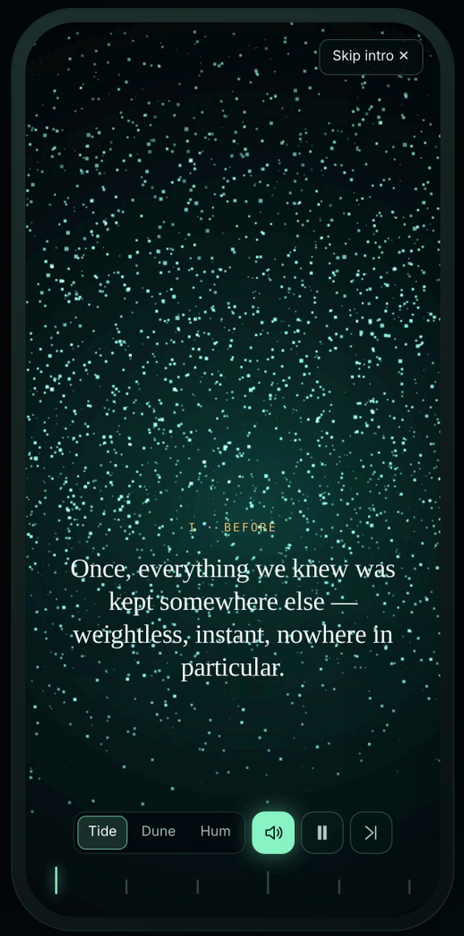
06 **Leave.** Compose on the Loom, or keep a record or whisper.

07 **Become.** Your earned name reveals itself.

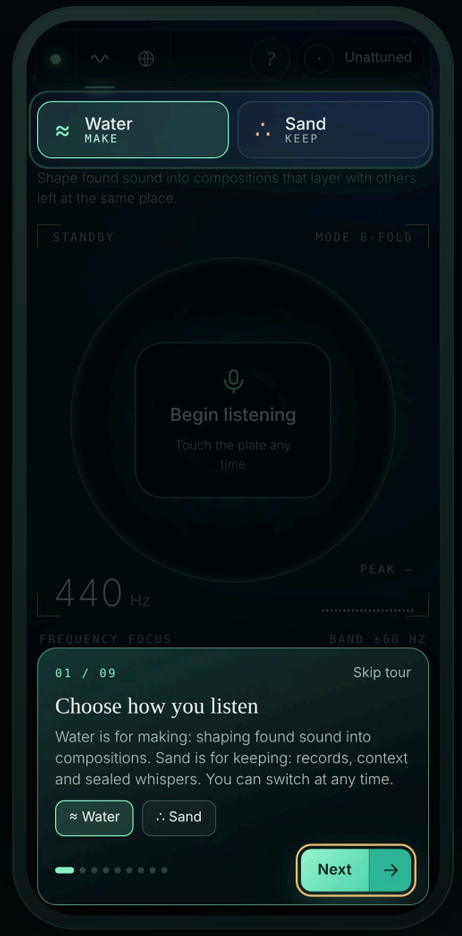
08 **See the world.** Every trace on the global map, live.



01 · THE START



01 · NARRATION ON TIDE



03 · COACH-MARK TOUR

PROCESS & ITERATIONS

Seven rounds, each *tested* and reviewed

Round 1
Foundation
Live archive, holographic radar and map, cymatics, Vicinity, Loom, whispers, names.

Round 2
First use
Coach-mark tour. Landing cut to one message.

Round 3
The intro
Six lines, skippable, shown once.

Round 4
Phone first
Reworked from 320 px, tour included.

Round 5
Navigation
Map tour, icon labels, one nav.

Round 6
Sound, not voice
TTS out. Three ambiences drive the visuals.

Round 7
Handover
README, credit and About, clean repo, live on Render.

WHAT THE FEEDBACK TAUGHT

The strongest changes came from removing things: the busy landing, the extra links, the synthetic voice.

BUGS FOUND AND FIXED

- Clip lost on 20 s auto-stop
- Duplicate offline saves
- Alert for your own trace
- Hidden submit on small screens
- Tour skipped with location on
- Overflow at 320 px

DESIGN SYSTEM

Small, so three pages *feel like one*

Ground
#04080B

Mint · Water
#8CF5C8

Gold · Sand
#E6BE76

Hum violet
#AEB8FF

Outfit — Interface and headlines

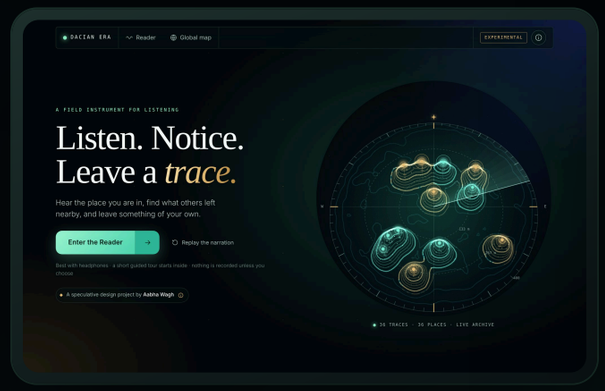
Newsreader — The voice of the world

JetBrains — Labels and readouts

- ◇ **One primary action** per screen
- ◇ **Sound first:** every moving visual follows audio
- ◇ **Thumb reach:** key controls low, targets ≥ 40 px
- ◇ **Ask in context:** mic and location when needed



LAPTOP · READER WITH THE LOOM OPEN



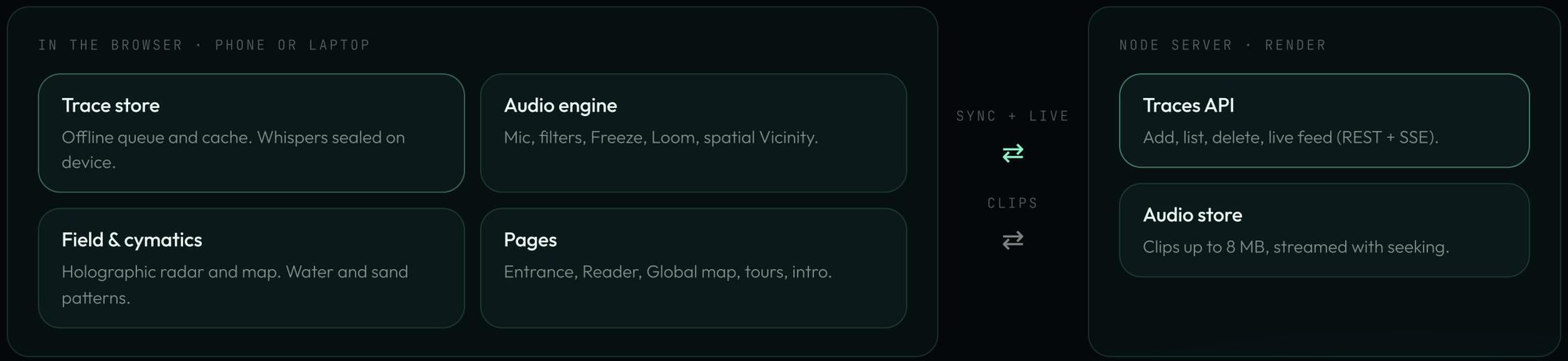
ENTRANCE



GLOBAL MAP

HOW IT WORKS

Every phone keeps a copy and *syncs one archive*



SHARED TEMPO

Each ~25 m patch has a tempo (72–96 BPM). Phones play in time without talking.

CYMATICS

Bessel waves for water, Chladni grains for sand. Pitch sets the mode.

SEALED WHISPERS

Encrypted on device with a place and pitch key. Opens within 25 m, ±8 Hz.

EARNED NAMES

Listening and making build a score; the Water/Sand share picks the name.

ETHICS, LIMITS, WHAT'S NEXT

An instrument that listens in public *carries responsibility*

BUILT IN

- **Nothing recorded** unless you choose
- **No accounts.** Delete with a private, hashed token
- **Permissions** asked in context, with reasons
- **Honest limits:** whispers are a ritual, not a vault
- **Place, not person:** no movement trails

LIMITS TODAY

- The archive starts empty; social features need people in the same places
- GPS is coarse indoors and in dense streets
- Not yet tested with participants in the field
- Open: consent of people audible in recordings, moderation, how long traces last

WHAT'S NEXT

- **Field testing** through soundwalks with participants
- **The Wanderer path:** listen, collect and curate
- **Decay:** traces fade unless revisited
- **More of the world:** Mendwave, Blood

Letting the world write the rules gave every feature a reason to exist.

CREATED BY

Aabha *Wagh*

World, concept, research, interaction and sound design direction, visual direction, writing, and every design decision in this project.

M.Des Human Centred Design · Srishti Manipal Institute of Art, Design and Technology

Try it live →

REFERENCES & RESOURCES

- The DACian Era world bible and Fillámend reference
- Reader – Entry Page Redesign
- Holographic topography and constellation references
- Chladni figures and Bessel standing waves
- Cymatics apps · soundwalking and field recording
- world-atlas land outlines (Natural Earth)
- Outfit, Newsreader, JetBrains Mono

Implementation support: code developed with AI assistance (Claude, by Anthropic) under the creator's direction and review.

© Aabha Wagh. The world, writing and design of The DACian Era are the creator's original work.